

Bell curve: When I write *bell curve* I mean the Gaussian bell curve, a.k.a. normal distribution. All curves look like bells, so this is a nickname. Also, when I write *the Gaussian basin* I mean all distributions that are similar and for which the improbable is inconsequential and of low impact (more technically, nonscalable—all moments are finite). Note that the visual presentation of the bell curve in histogram form masks the contribution of the remote event, as such an event will be a point to the far right or far left of the center.

Diamonds: See Eco (2002).

Platonicity: I'm simply referring to incurring the risk of using a wrong form—not that forms don't exist. I am not against essentialisms; I am often skeptical of our reverse engineering and identification of the right form. It is an inverse problem!

Empiricist: If I call myself an empiricist, or an empirical philosopher, it is because I am just suspicious of confirmatory generalizations and hasty theorizing. Do not confuse this with the British empiricist tradition. Also, many statisticians, as we will see with the Makridakis competition, call themselves “empirical” researchers, but are in fact just the opposite—they fit theories to the past.

Mention of Christ: See Flavius Josephus's *The Jewish War*.

Great War and prediction: Ferguson (2006b).

Hindsight bias (retrospective distortion): See Fischhoff (1982b).

Historical fractures: Braudel (1985), p. 169, quotes a little known passage from Gautier. He writes, “‘This long history,’ wrote Emile-Félix Gautier, ‘lasted a dozen centuries, longer than the entire history of France. Encountering the first Arab sword, the Greek language and thought, all that heritage went up in smoke, as if it never happened.’” For discussions of discontinuity, see also Gurvitch (1957), Braudel (1953), Harris (2004).

Religions spread as bestsellers: Veyne (1971). See also Veyne (2005).

Clustering in political opinions: Pinker (2002).

Categories: Rosch (1973, 1978). See also Umberto Eco's *Kant and the Platypus*.

Historiography and philosophy of history: Bloch (1953), Carr (1961),